

Narrative Nuances: Exploring the Association between Preferences for Narrative Complexity in Mainstream Media, Viewers' Cognitive Styles and Political Ideology.

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Gaia Yonah^a <https://orcid.org/0009-0004-2870-1842>

Cynthia Cabañas^a <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-2920-3907>

Mariken van der Velden^a <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-0227-9183>

Katalin Bálint^a <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-6254-7883>

Elly Konijn^a <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-6134-8700>

^a Department of Communication Science, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, Amsterdam, The Netherlands

Corresponding Author

Cynthia Cabañas

Department of Communication Science, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam

De Boelelaan 1105, 1081 HV Amsterdam, The Netherlands

Email: cynthiacabanas@gmail.com

Abstract (198 words)

Narrational complexity—such as nonlinearity, ambiguity, delayed closure, and shifting perspectives—has become prominent in mainstream film and television, yet little is known about who is drawn to complex storytelling and what such preferences reveal beyond entertainment taste. This study examines whether preference for narrational complexity reflects broader cognitive styles and political orientation, thereby linking media psychology with political psychology. Using structural equation modeling with a representative Dutch sample ($N = 2,311$), we tested how preferences for, and reported exposure to, narrationally complex mainstream cinema relate to tolerance for ambiguity, need for cognition, ideological self-placement, and voting intention. Higher tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition were associated with stronger preference for narrational complexity and with less conservative and less right-wing ideological self-placement. The association between progressive–conservative ideology and preference for narrational complexity was largely attenuated after accounting for cognitive styles, suggesting that ideology and narrative preference partly share cognitive-dispositional foundations. Lower preference for narrational complexity was also associated with more conservative voting intention. These findings extend research on political orientation and media preference by showing that political differences in entertainment preference may concern not only content, genre, or values, but also the formal complexity of storytelling.

Narrational complexity has become a prominent feature of mainstream cinematic storytelling (Bordwell, 2023; Buckland, 2009; Kiss & Willemsen, 2017; Mittell, 2015). This trend is evident in mainstream films such as *Inception* (2010) and *Everything Everywhere All at Once* (2022), as well as TV series like *Severance* (2022–present). Narrationally complex narratives are typically characterized by structural features such as non-linear timelines, intersecting plotlines, shifting perspectives or the strategic withholding of information, all of which require viewers to actively construct meaning from fragmented or uncertain narrative cues (Cabañas et al., 2026; Kiss & Willemsen, 2017). Their mainstream visibility suggests that cognitively demanding storytelling continues to occupy an important place in popular entertainment, even as contemporary media environments increasingly privilege short-form, accessible, easy-to-consume content (Eddy, 2024).

This trend also has broader societal relevance. As contemporary societies become more structurally and informationally complex (OECD, 2023), the ability to process, tolerate, and even enjoy complexity is increasingly important (Ang, 2011). Understanding who gravitates toward complexity in narrative media may therefore offer a useful window into broader differences in how individuals respond to complexity, ambiguity and uncertainty in everyday life.

This question speaks to a wider debate in media psychology about what entertainment preferences reveal about their audiences. Research on media selection has primarily focused on the content of media exposure: the themes, messages, genres, and ideological cues embedded in the media people consume (e.g. Knobloch-Westerwick, 2015; Stroud, 2008; Xu & Peterson, 2017). This is especially true in selective-exposure research, which has examined whether people choose media that align with their political attitudes, values and worldviews (Iyengar & Hahn, 2009; Stroud, 2008). This focus has produced important insights into politically motivated media

choices, but it leaves open a different question: whether political orientation is also related to preferences for how a narrative is told.

This question matters because narrational complexity fundamentally shapes the experience of viewing. Complex narratives challenge fluent comprehension by disrupting viewers' ability to construct and maintain coherent mental representations of the unfolding story, requiring them to repeatedly generate, update, and revise their interpretations as new information becomes available (Cabañas et al., 2026). Preference for such stories may therefore indicate a broader orientation toward effortful information processing and greater comfort with ambiguity and uncertainty. In this sense, the present study contributes to debates about whether entertainment preferences should be understood primarily as expressions of taste and entertainment motivations or also as indicators of broader cognitive styles.

Consistent with this perspective, preference for narrationally complex films has been linked to cognitive styles such as need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity (Willemsen et al., 2022). Importantly, these same cognitive styles have also been linked to ideological orientation. For instance, lower tolerance for ambiguity has frequently been associated with more conservative political attitudes (Bakker et al., 2021; Jost et al., 2003), whereas higher need for cognition has been associated with less conservative political orientations and greater willingness to engage with complex political information (Bakker, 2022; Carney et al., 2008; Jost et al., 2017). Taken together, these lines of work suggest that preference for narrational complexity may link insights from media psychology and political science: the same cognitive dispositions associated to how individuals respond to ambiguity and cognitive effort in entertainment may also relate to how they orient themselves politically.

The present study addresses this possibility using survey data from a representative Dutch sample (N = 2,311). We examine how preferences for, and reported exposure to, narrationally complex mainstream cinema relate to cognitive styles, political orientation and voting intention. We predict that greater preference for narrational complexity will be associated with higher tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition, and that these cognitive styles, in turn, will be associated with less conservative political orientation and voting intention. We further explore whether similar patterns extend to reported exposure to narrationally complex media.

Theoretical Background

The theoretical argument proceeds in three steps. First, we argue that preferences for narrational complexity may be politically relevant because media preferences can reflect not only preferred content but also preferred modes of processing information. Second, we propose that need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity are particularly relevant to this relationship because they shape how viewers respond to the cognitive demands of complex narratives. Third, we argue that these same cognitive styles are associated with political ideology, making them a plausible mechanism linking preference for narrational complexity to political orientation.

Political Ideology and Media Preferences

Research on media selection has long sought to explain why people choose particular kinds of media. *Uses and gratifications theory* (Katz et al., 1973; Rubin, 2009) proposes that audiences actively select media in ways that align with their psychological needs and motivations. Applied to the present study, this suggests that viewers may differ in the extent to which they seek out challenging narratives as a source of cognitive stimulation or interpretive involvement. A related perspective is offered by *elective affinities* (Jost et al., 2003), according to which people tend to gravitate toward cultural products that fit with their existing dispositions

and habitual ways of making sense of the world (Iyengar & Hahn, 2009; Stroud, 2008). This framework is relevant to political orientation because ideological belief systems have been associated with different ways of managing uncertainty, order, closure, and complexity (Bakker et al., 2021; Carney et al., 2008; Jost et al., 2003, 2009, 2017; Jost & Kende, 2020). From this perspective, political ideology may partly reflect differences in how people respond to epistemic demands, which may in turn translate into different media preferences.

Consistent with this reasoning, previous research suggests that entertainment preferences often align with broader moral and ideological orientations. Long and Eveland (2021), for example, found that the moral content of the music genres respondents preferred or consumed was associated with their own moral foundations and political ideology. Similarly, Xu et al. (2021) showed that different dimensions of conservative attitudes were associated with distinct entertainment preferences, including preferences for active, masculine, communal, cerebral, nonfiction, and alternative genres. Extending this line of work, Nai et al. (2026) found experimental evidence that ideological cues about pop artists can shape musical preferences and that musical cues may, under some conditions, also influence political attitudes. These studies illustrate that entertainment preferences can be politically meaningful, but they focus primarily on content, genre, values, or moral themes. Whether similar associations extend to preferences for narrative structures, that is, how stories organize and present narrative information, remains largely unexplored.

According to the Triadic Engagement with Narrational Complexity (TENCo) framework, different storytelling structures place different cognitive demands on viewers by requiring varying degrees of active inference, integration of dispersed information, and revision of evolving mental representations during comprehension (Cabañas et al., 2026). Engagement with

narrationally complex narratives therefore depends on adopting an effortful processing stance, whereby viewers actively construct and continuously update their understanding as the story unfolds. TENCo further argues that the propensity to adopt and sustain this processing stance varies across individuals. While some viewers may find this process rewarding, others may experience it as frustrating.

Narrationally complex stories may therefore be politically relevant not only because of their themes or values, but because they require a particular mode of engagement. They invite viewers to tolerate delayed understanding, integrate dispersed information, and remain involved despite uncertainty. These formal properties may make such narratives more appealing to viewers who are more comfortable with cognitive complexity and interpretive openness, and less appealing to viewers who prefer clearer structure, closure, and immediate coherence. Building on this reasoning, the present study predicts:

H1. *Individuals with a) more conservative and b) more right-wing political ideology are expected to report a lower preference for narrational complexity.*

Extending beyond ideological self-placement, the present study also examines whether preference for narrational complexity is associated with voting intention. This is important because ideological self-placement and electoral choice do not always map onto one another straightforwardly. Vote choice may also reflect partisan identification, political sophistication, ambivalence, issue priorities, and heuristic decision-making (Federico & Malka, 2021; Lauener, 2020). Voting intention therefore provides a complementary indicator of political orientation, capturing whether the proposed association extends from abstract ideological self-placement to intended political behavior. On this basis, the study predicts:

H2. *Individuals with a lower preference for narrational complexity are expected to report more conservative voting intentions.*

Cognitive styles as an explanatory mechanism

The preceding section argued that preference for narrational complexity may be politically relevant because complex narratives require a distinctive mode of engagement rather than merely exposing viewers to particular themes or values. The next question is why some viewers are more willing than others to adopt this mode of engagement. We argue that stable cognitive styles provide a plausible explanation. Two cognitive styles are especially relevant because they shape individuals' willingness to engage with cognitive challenge and uncertainty: need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity.

Need for cognition refers to a stable tendency to enjoy and engage in effortful cognitive activity (Cacioppo & Petty, 1982). Viewers higher in need for cognition may be more likely to experience puzzles, complex timelines and high information load as stimulating rather than taxing. Earlier work in communication science and media psychology also suggests that need for cognition is associated with differences in media selection, attention, and processing style. Higher need for cognition has been linked to greater attention to informational media and to more active forms of genre engagement, whereas lower need for cognition has been associated with heavier television viewing and more escapist patterns of use (e.g., Hawkins et al., 2001; Henning & Vorderer, 2001; Perse, 1992). In this sense, need for cognition may shape not only how viewers process demanding media, but also the extent to which they are drawn to media that require cognitive involvement.

Tolerance for ambiguity refers to the extent to which individuals are comfortable with uncertainty, incompleteness, and multiple possible interpretations (Budner, 1962; Furnham &

Marks, 2013). This disposition is closely aligned with narrationally complex stories, which often delay closure, withhold causal information, leave interpretive gaps or invite competing explanations. Viewers higher in tolerance for ambiguity may be more willing to remain engaged when understanding is incomplete or when a narrative resists immediate coherence. This is relevant not only to media preferences but also to broader information processing, as tolerance for ambiguity has been linked to openness toward uncertain or unfamiliar situations and to more flexible engagement with unresolved information (Stoycheva, 2025). Consistent with this broader perspective, research on eudaimonic media similarly suggests that stable psychological differences can be linked to preferences for more reflective and meaningful forms of media experiences (Lapierre & Choi, 2025). Although eudaimonic media and narrationally complex media are distinct constructs, both involve forms of engagement that extend beyond immediate pleasure and straightforward processing.

More directly, Willemsen et al. (2022) found that need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity were positively associated with preference for narrative complexity, although the relationships were differentiated. Need for cognition was the strongest predictor of preference for cognitive challenge, whereas tolerance for ambiguity was the strongest predictor of preference for nonclosure. Because this evidence was based on a relatively small sample of English-speaking participants, the present study examines whether they generalize to a representative Dutch sample. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

H3. *Individuals with higher tolerance for ambiguity and higher need for cognition are expected to report greater preference for narrative complexity.*

Cognitive styles and political orientation

Beyond shaping media preferences, cognitive styles have also been linked to political ideology. According to motivated social cognition accounts, ideological orientations differ systematically in the extent to which they satisfy motivations for certainty, order, and closure (Jost et al., 2003; 2009; 2017). From this perspective, conservative ideology tends to be especially appealing to individuals who are less comfortable with uncertainty and ambiguity because it emphasizes tradition, familiar norms, clear social boundaries, and resistance to change, thereby providing greater certainty, structure, and closure than more progressive or liberal orientations (Jost et al., 2003; 2009; 2017).

A similar pattern has been observed for need for cognition. Individuals lower in need for cognition are less inclined to engage in effortful, reflective information processing and may rely more readily on familiar cues, heuristics, or readily available interpretations (Cacioppo et al., 1996). By contrast, higher need for cognition has been associated with greater willingness to engage with complexity, consider competing viewpoints, and revise judgments in light of new information, tendencies that are generally more compatible with less conservative orientations (Bakker, 2022; Carney et al., 2008; Jost et al., 2017).

These relationships, however, are unlikely to be equally strong across all dimensions of political ideology. Federico and Malka (2018), for example, argue that epistemic motivations such as preferences for certainty and security are more consistently associated with sociocultural than economic conservatism. Consequently, associations between cognitive styles and general measures of ideology may vary depending on how different political issues are organized within a particular political context. In some countries, positions on sociocultural and economic issues tend to align closely, whereas in others they are more independent. As a result, broad ideological labels such as “left” and “right” or “progressive” and “conservative” may capture somewhat

different constellations of political attitudes across contexts. To account for this, the present study assesses ideological orientation using both left–right and progressive–conservative self-placement. Despite these considerations, existing theory and empirical evidence suggest that individuals lower in tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition should place themselves further to the political right and as more conservative. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

H4. *Individuals with lower tolerance for ambiguity and lower need for cognition are expected to report more right-wing and more conservative ideological self-placement.*

Finally, if preference for narrational complexity and political ideology are both related to cognitive styles, then cognitive styles should partly account for the ideology–preference association. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

H5. *The association between preference for narrational complexity and political ideology will be attenuated after accounting for individual differences in tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition.*

Exploratory research questions

Self-reported preferences do not always translate directly into real-world media use (Parry et al., 2021). The present study, therefore, also examines self-reported exposure to narrationally complex films and television series. This distinction is theoretically important: whereas preference captures the subjective appeal of narrational complexity, exposure reflects the extent to which such preferences are enacted under real-world conditions shaped by habit, familiarity, access, and availability. Nevertheless, individuals who report stronger preferences for narrational complexity would be expected to report greater exposure to such narratives.

Accordingly, the following exploratory questions are posed:

***RQ1.** Is reported exposure to narrationally complex films and television shows associated with tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition?*

***RQ2.** Is reported exposure to narrationally complex films and television shows associated with political ideology?*

Method

Design, Procedure, and Participants

The present study used data from the 2023 VU Election Studies, a four-wave online panel survey administered by KiesKompas, a Dutch polling company, between October and November 2023. Participants were members of the KiesKompas panel and took part voluntarily, without financial compensation. Although the panel was based on an opt-in sample, efforts were made to approximate the Dutch population on key demographic characteristics. The present analyses draw on a subset of variables from the larger VU Election Study dataset (Van der Velden, 2023). The full survey sample comprised 2,400 Dutch adults. After providing informed consent, participants completed a large battery of questionnaires presented in randomized order. The measures used in the present study assessed tolerance for ambiguity, need for cognition, preference for narrational complexity, exposure to narrationally complex media, political self-placement on both left–right and progressive–conservative dimensions, and voting intention. At the end of the survey, participants were thanked and debriefed.

The primary structural equation model (SEM) was estimated on 2,311 respondents with complete data on the continuous study variables. In this analytic sample, the mean age was 57.0 years ($SD = 16.6$), 41.5% were women ($N = 959$), and 58.5% were men ($N = 1,352$). Analyses involving voting intention were conducted on a reduced subsample of 2,007 respondents because the voting variable was operationalized as a binary progressive-versus-conservative indicator,

which required excluding cases with missing or nonclassifiable responses. Within this subsample, 39.2% ($N = 787$) were classified as having a progressive voting intention and 60.8% ($N = 1,220$) as having a conservative voting intention. The study was approved by the Research Ethics Review Committee of the authors' institution (2023-10-30-660). Additional analytical details are reported in the Online Compendium.

Measures

Preference for Narrational Complexity

Preference for narrational complexity (PNC) was measured with 23 5-point Likert-items from Willemsen et al. (2022), with higher values indicating a stronger preference for narrational complexity. Items cover six features of complexity appreciation: Nonclosure (e.g., "Open endings in films spark my interest"), Puzzles (e.g., "I enjoy films that require some thinking to understand the story"), Information Load, Temporalities (e.g., time shifts), Twists (e.g., "I enjoy stories with unforeseen twists and turns"), and Incongruities (e.g., "A paradox in a story piques my interest"). Given the scale's multidimensionality, reliability was estimated using McDonald's omega based on polychoric correlations. The general PNC composite showed good internal consistency ($\omega_{\text{total}} = .89$) and substantial general-factor saturation ($\omega_{\text{h}} = .69$), supporting the use of an overall PNC score in the primary analyses. (Descriptive statistics appear in Table 1).

Exposure to Complex Narratives

To assess self-reported exposure to narrationally complex media, we compiled a list of 14 popular films and television series featuring narrationally complex storytelling. The selection was based on IMDb keywords indicative of narrative complexity, such as "puzzle," "mind-game," and "complex," and titles were required to have a rating above 8.0. We emphasized viewer ratings, cultural relevance, and genre diversity, and the final list was validated through

consultation with a film studies expert. The list included *Westworld* (HBO), *Dark* (Netflix), *Twin Peaks* (Showtime), *Lost* (ABC), *Mr. Robot* (USA Network), *Black Mirror* (Channel 4/Netflix), *Euphoria* (HBO), *Severance* (Apple TV+), *Arrival* (2016), *Interstellar* (2014), *Inception* (2010), *Mulholland Drive* (2001), *Primer* (2004), and *Memento* (2000). Images of each film or series were displayed to help participants recognize the titles.

For each title, participants indicated whether and to what extent they had seen it, ranging from no exposure to partial exposure, full exposure, and repeated exposure. These responses were coded to capture degree of exposure rather than simple title recognition or binary viewing. Item-level exposure scores were then averaged across the 14 titles and multiplied by 100 to create an overall narrational complexity exposure index, with higher scores indicating greater cumulative exposure to narrationally complex films and series. This composite therefore reflects both the number of titles participants had encountered and the extent to which they had viewed them. Omega's reliability coefficient for the exposure index was .94, indicating satisfactory internal consistency.

Tolerance of Ambiguity

Tolerance of ambiguity (TOA) was assessed using the MSTAT-II scale (McLain, 2009), which consisted of 13 items (e.g., "I try to avoid situations that are ambiguous") on a Likert scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree. The internal consistency of the scale was acceptable ($\omega = .70$) (Descriptive statistics appear in Table 1.).

Need for Cognition

The need for cognition (NFC) was assessed via the NFC-6 scale (Coelho et al., 2020) through six items (e.g., "I really enjoy a task that involves coming up with new solutions to

problems”) on a Likert scale from 1= strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree. The internal consistency of the scale was satisfactory ($\alpha = .81$) (Descriptive statistics appear in Table 1.).

Political Ideology

Ideology Self-placement. Participants' political ideology was assessed using a two-item scale (Jost et al., 2009), which evaluates political-ideological self-placement along two dimensions: *a right-left spectrum* (ranging from 1-10, 1=left) and *a conservative-progressive spectrum* (ranging from 1-10, 1=progressive).

Voting Intention. Participants were asked to state their voting intention, which provided a tangible measure of their ideological leanings. Participants indicated which party they intended to vote for in the upcoming election. This was operationalized by presenting them with all parties that were in the parliament as well as new political parties that were, according to the aggregated polls (peilingwijzer.nl), likely to enter parliament after the elections (VVD, D66, PVV, CDA, SP, PvdA/GroenLinks, Forum voor Democratie, Partij voor de Dieren, ChristenUnie, JA21, SGP, Volt, Denk, 50Plus, BoerBurgerBeweging (BBB), BIJ1, Nieuw Sociaal Contract, BVNL, Blank note, other party, or not intending to vote). Using KiesKompas' positions, each party was categorized as “conservative” or “progressive”. Consequently, participants received a score of 1, indicating a conservative voting intention, or 0, indicating a progressive voting intention. This method enables a multidimensional evaluation of political ideology, capturing both self-perception and an action-oriented dimension of political behavior.

Results

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics and bivariate correlations among the study variables. Preference for narrational complexity (PNC) was positively and significantly correlated with both tolerance for ambiguity (ToA) and need for cognition (NfC). PNC was also

negatively correlated with both ideological conservatism and conservative voting intention. Reported exposure to narrationally complex media was positively associated with PNC, ToA, and NfC, and negatively associated with ideological conservatism and conservative voting intention. These bivariate patterns provided preliminary support for the hypothesized relationships.

[Table 1]

Data Analysis

Structural equation models (SEMs) were estimated in R using the lavaan package (Rosseel, 2012). Preliminary modeling indicated that tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition were strongly correlated and were more parsimoniously represented as indicators of a single latent factor. Accordingly, subsequent SEM analyses modeled these variables as indicators of a latent cognitive-styles factor capturing the shared tendency toward ambiguity tolerance and need for cognition.

The primary SEM (used to test H1, H3 and H4) examined associations among the latent cognitive-styles factor, political ideology, preference for narrational complexity, and exposure to narrationally complex media. Progressive–conservative self-placement and left–right self-placement were regressed on the latent cognitive styles factor; PNC was regressed on the latent cognitive styles factor and both ideology measures; and exposure to complex narratives was regressed on PNC, the latent cognitive styles factor, and both ideology measures. Age, sex, and education were included as covariates for all endogenous variables. Because the exposure variable showed substantially greater variance than the remaining observed variables, it was standardized prior to estimation. This model was estimated using robust maximum likelihood

(MLR) with full information maximum likelihood for missing data and was based on 2,311 respondents.

A separate SEM was estimated for voting intention using WLSMV, because voting intention was coded as a binary variable (progressive vs. conservative). This model was based on 2,007 respondents with complete data on all included variables and a classifiable voting intention. To test H5, a reduced SEM in which PNC was predicted by ideology and covariates only was compared with a full SEM in which the latent cognitive-styles factor was additionally included as a predictor of PNC.

Model Fit

The primary SEM showed good fit to the data, $\chi^2(6) = 23.40, p = .001$, robust CFI = .993, robust TLI = .964, robust RMSEA = .036, 90% CI [.021, .052], and SRMR = .010. The model explained 26.3% of the variance in the latent cognitive-styles factor, 22.3% of the variance in PNC, 9.0% of the variance in exposure to narrationally complex media, 7.6% of the variance in progressive–conservative self-placement, and 6.7% of the variance in left–right self-placement. The voting-intention SEM also showed good fit, $\chi^2(6) = 37.01, p < .001$, CFI = .994, TLI = .986, RMSEA = .037, 90% CI [.021, .054], and SRMR = .018. This model explained 77.0% of the variance in voting intention.

[Table 2]

Hypothesis Testing

[Figure 1]

H1 predicted that a more conservative political ideology would be associated with a lower preference for narrational complexity. This hypothesis received partial support. In the full SEM, progressive–conservative self-placement was not a significant unique predictor of PNC, β

$= -.029, p = .210$, whereas left–right self-placement significantly predicted lower PNC, $\beta = -.072, z = -3.17, p = .002$. Thus, H1 was supported for left–right ideology but not for progressive–conservative self-placement once cognitive styles and the alternative ideology measure were controlled. The size of this association was small, suggesting that left–right ideology explains only a modest share of unique variance in PNC.

H2 predicted that individuals with a lower preference for narrational complexity would report more conservative voting intentions. This hypothesis was tested in the separate voting-intention SEM. As predicted, PNC was negatively associated with conservative voting intention, $\beta = -.070, z = -3.07, p = .002$. Individuals with a stronger preference for narrational complexity were therefore less likely to report a conservative voting intention, although the standardized association was small.

H3 predicted that individuals higher in tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition would report a greater preference for narrational complexity. Tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition loaded strongly on the latent cognitive-styles factor (ToA: $\beta = .690, p < .001$; NfC: $\beta = .767, p < .001$). As predicted, higher scores on this latent factor were associated with greater PNC, $\beta = .388, z = 12.43, p < .001$. This was the strongest structural association in the model, indicating that cognitive styles were more strongly related to PNC than were the ideology measures.

H4 predicted that lower tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition would be associated with more conservative political orientations. This hypothesis was supported. Higher scores on the latent cognitive-styles factor were associated with less conservative progressive–conservative self-placement, $\beta = -.217, z = -6.98, p < .001$, and less right-leaning left–right self-

placement, $\beta = -.060$, $z = -2.00$, $p = .046$. The association was stronger for the progressive–conservative dimension than for the left–right dimension.

H5 proposed that cognitive styles would attenuate the association between political ideology and PNC. This hypothesis received partial support. In the reduced model, conservative self-placement significantly predicted lower PNC, $\beta = -.100$, $p < .001$. After the latent cognitive-styles factor was added, this association was substantially reduced and became non-significant, $\beta = -.029$, $p = .208$. This pattern is consistent with attenuation and suggests that shared variance with tolerance for ambiguity and need for cognition accounts for much of the association between progressive–conservative ideology and PNC. For left–right self-placement, however, the association with PNC remained significant after the latent factor was included. In the reduced model, more right self-placement predicted lower PNC, $\beta = -.058$, $p = .013$, and in the full model, the association remained significant, $\beta = -.072$, $p = .002$. H5 was therefore supported for progressive–conservative ideology but not for left–right ideology.

Exploratory Research Questions

Research Question 1 asked whether exposure to narrationally complex media was associated with cognitive styles. In the primary SEM, the association between cognitive styles and exposure was positive but fell just short of conventional significance, $\beta = .062$, $z = 1.86$, $p = .063$. Thus, the SEM provided only weak evidence for an association between cognitive styles and exposure after accounting for preference and ideology.

Research Question 2 asked whether exposure to narrationally complex media was associated with political ideology. In the primary SEM, neither ideology measure significantly predicted exposure after PNC and cognitive styles were controlled (progressive–conservative: β

= .012, $p = .635$; left–right: $\beta = -.038$, $p = .099$). Thus, the SEM provided no clear evidence that ideological self-placement independently predicted exposure in the full model.

Exploratory analysis

An additional exploratory analysis examined whether self-reported exposure differed by voting intention. In a logistic regression predicting reported exposure to narrationally complex media, conservative voting intention was associated with significantly lower odds of exposure, controlling for age, sex, and education, $OR = 0.71$, 95% CI [0.58, 0.86], $p < .001$. Because this analysis was exploratory and based on a binary exposure indicator, the finding should be interpreted as preliminary evidence that conservative voting intention is associated with lower self-reported exposure to the narrationally complex titles included in the study.

Covariates

Among the covariates, age and education showed the clearest and most consistent associations. Older respondents scored lower on the latent cognitive-styles factor, reported lower PNC, and reported lower exposure to narrationally complex media. Higher education was positively associated with the latent cognitive-styles factor and negatively associated with right-leaning political orientation and conservative voting intention. Men scored slightly higher on the latent cognitive-styles factor and also reported more conservative ideological self-placement than women.

Full standardized and unstandardized parameter estimates for the final structural equation models are presented in Table 3.

Discussion

This study examined whether preference for narrational complexity is associated with cognitive styles, political orientation, voting intention and exposure to narrationally complex media. Using structural equation modeling with a representative Dutch sample, we found that preference for narrational complexity was positively associated with need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity and, to a lesser extent, with political orientation and voting intention. Cognitive styles largely accounted for the association between progressive–conservative self-placement and narrative preference, whereas left–right self-placement retained a modest independent association. By contrast, reported exposure showed a weaker and less consistent pattern of associations.

More broadly, these findings suggest that politically relevant differences in entertainment preference extend beyond preferences for content to preferences for the organization of narrative information. At the same time, the differing results across ideological measures and between preference and exposure indicate that these relationships are neither uniform nor direct. Rather, they depend both on how political orientation is conceptualized and on the contextual factors that shape media consumption.

Political Differences in Preferences for Narrational Complexity

In line with the expectation that political orientation would be associated with preference for narrational complexity, more conservative ideological orientations were generally associated with lower preference for narrationally complex stories. A similar pattern emerged for voting intention, with respondents reporting lower preference for narrational complexity being more likely to express a conservative voting intention.

Previous work has shown that entertainment preferences can align with political orientations through genre, values, or symbolic content (Long & Eveland, 2021; Xu et al., 2021).

The present findings extend this literature by suggesting that political differences in entertainment preference may also concern *how* stories are structured and experienced, not only *what* they are about. More broadly, these findings indicate that narrational complexity may represent a previously overlooked dimension of politically meaningful media preferences, one that is largely independent of a narrative's thematic or ideological content.

The association with voting intention further suggests that preferences for narrational complexity may relate not only to ideological self-placement but also to intended political behavior. This finding is consistent with the rationale for including voting intention as a complementary indicator of political orientation, although it should be interpreted cautiously given the cross-sectional design since it does not permit conclusions about the direction of this relationship.

Cognitive Styles Partly Explain Political Differences in Narrative Preference

Cognitive styles help explain why preference for narrational complexity and political orientation are related. Consistent with our hypotheses, individuals higher in need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity reported stronger preferences for narrationally complex stories and less conservative ideological self-placement. These findings replicate and extend previous work showing that preference for narrational complexity is associated with these cognitive dispositions (Willemssen et al., 2022), while also supporting political psychology research linking conservatism to stronger preferences for certainty, order, structure, and closure (Bakker et al., 2021; Jost et al., 2003, 2009, 2017).

The present findings are also consistent with the TENCo framework (Cabañas et al., 2026), which proposes that individual differences in cognitive dispositions such as need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity contribute to variation in preferences for, and engagement

with, narrationally complex stories. The present findings extend these initial observations by replicating these associations in a representative Dutch sample and by showing that these same cognitive dispositions are also related to political orientation. One notable finding was that the associations differed across the two measures of ideological self-placement. Whereas the association with progressive–conservative self-placement was largely accounted for by need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity, the association with left–right self-placement remained, albeit modestly, after these cognitive styles were taken into account.

This difference is consistent with work suggesting that epistemic motivations are not equally related to all dimensions of political ideology (Federico & Malka, 2018). In European political systems, left–right self-placement often combines positions on both economic and sociocultural issues, whereas progressive–conservative self-placement more directly reflects attitudes toward social change and tradition (de Vries & Marks, 2012). Against this background, it is perhaps unsurprising that cognitive styles largely accounted for the association with progressive–conservative self-placement, whereas left–right self-placement retained a modest independent association. This suggests that the latter captures additional political dimensions beyond those associated with need for cognition and tolerance for ambiguity. Future research should therefore examine more specific ideological constructs, including cultural and economic conservatism, authoritarianism, traditionalism, and party identification, to clarify which aspects of political orientation are most closely associated with preferences for narrational complexity.

A complementary interpretation comes from research on challenging media selection. Eden et al. (2018) found that participants who imagined themselves in a depleted state were less likely to select cognitively and affectively challenging films and more likely to select films expected to be fun and less demanding. Their work suggests that media choice partly depends on

the fit between the demands of media content and the cognitive or self-regulatory resources available to the viewer. The present findings extend this logic from temporary self-regulatory states to more stable cognitive styles: viewers who generally enjoy cognitive effort and tolerate ambiguity may be more likely to experience narrational complexity as rewarding rather than aversive, making them more likely to seek out such narratives.. In this sense, preference for narrational complexity may reflect a perceived fit between the demands of a narrative form and the viewer's habitual mode of processing information.

This interpretation also resonates with recent work suggesting that some audiences are drawn to forms of entertainment that extend beyond immediate hedonic gratification, whether through reflection and meaning (Lapierre & Choi, 2025) or through psychologically rich experiences characterized by novelty, interest, and cognitive engagement (Wirz et al., 2025). From this perspective, narrational complexity may be valued not despite its cognitive demands but because those demands provide opportunities for richer cognitive engagement.

Preference Versus Exposure

The distinction between preference and reported exposure proved theoretically informative. In selective exposure research, preferences are understood as general tendencies to favor particular kinds of media content, which may materialize in repeated choices, whereas exposure reflects more concrete acts or patterns of media consumption (Knobloch-Westerwick, 2015). Consistent with this perspective, preference and reported exposure were positively associated, indicating that individuals who enjoy narrationally complex stories are indeed more likely to seek them out. However, the association was only moderate, suggesting that attraction to narrational complexity is only one determinant of real-world media consumption. This interpretation is reinforced by the finding that, whereas need for cognition and tolerance for

ambiguity were robustly associated with preferences for narrational complexity, their associations with reported exposure were comparatively weak. Preference reflects the subjective appeal of narrational complexity, whereas exposure reflects enacted media behavior, which is additionally shaped by contextual factors such as platform access, title availability, cultural familiarity, age cohort, social recommendation, genre habits, and recognition of the specific films and series included in the measure.

The exploratory analyses involving voting intention point in a potentially interesting direction. Conservative voting intention was associated with lower odds of reporting exposure to narrationally complex media. This suggests that voting intention may reflect a more behaviorally anchored indicator of political orientation than ideological self-placement alone. One possible interpretation is that exposure to narrationally complex media is connected to broader cultural and political repertoires associated with voting behavior. This interpretation is consistent with research suggesting that political orientations are reflected in broader patterns of cultural taste and consumption (DellaPosta et al., 2015; Rogers & Jost, 2022), including media consumption (Fioroni et al., 2022), and with evidence linking lifestyle and cultural preferences to voting behavior (Cavazza & Corbetta, 2016). However, this finding should be treated as tentative. Differences in title familiarity, age-related viewing habits, cultural repertoires, genre preferences and broader media-use patterns could also explain the association.

Broader Implications

More broadly, the present findings suggest that narrational complexity should be studied not only as a formal property of narratives but also as a psychologically meaningful dimension of media selection. Although narrational complexity resides in the structure of the narrative itself, attraction to this formal property varies systematically across individuals according to their

cognitive dispositions. This positions narrational complexity as a useful domain for investigating how stable psychological characteristics shape engagement with cognitively demanding cultural forms. These findings are particularly relevant in the context of increasingly complex social and media environments (OECD, 2023), where engagement with ambiguity, uncertainty, and interpretive effort has become a more common feature of everyday information processing (Ang, 2011). These insights may also inform media literacy initiatives, cultural programming, and public communication strategies aimed at engaging diverse audiences with narratively demanding content.

Limitations and Future Directions

Several limitations should be acknowledged. First, the study is cross-sectional, which limits causal inference. The statistical analyses were theoretically informed, but they model associations rather than temporal or causal direction. Cognitive styles may shape narrative preferences and ideological alignment, but repeated engagement with certain media forms may also cultivate interpretive habits, and broader educational, social, or cultural experiences may contribute to all three. Reinforcing-spiral perspectives suggest that media use can both reflect prior orientations and contribute to their maintenance through repeated exposure (Slater, 2007, 2015). Applied to narrative form, this raises the possibility that repeated engagement with narrationally complex media may not only reflect existing cognitive styles but also strengthen preferences for ambiguity, interpretive effort, and open-ended meaning over time. The present study therefore provides an initial population-level map of these associations, which future longitudinal and experimental studies should test more directly.

Second, all measures were self-reported. This is appropriate for subjective and dispositional constructs such as political self-placement, need for cognition, tolerance for

ambiguity, and media preferences (Chan, 2009; Paulhus & Vazire, 2007). The greater limitation concerns reported exposure, which depends on memory, recognition, and self-assessed viewing extent. Prior work on media-use measurement shows that self-reported exposure can diverge from behavioral logs and may be affected by recall and estimation error (Parry et al., 2021; Prior, 2009). Thus, the observed associations remain informative about perceived preferences and reported media repertoires, but future studies should combine self-report with behavioral indicators, such as viewing logs, platform data, diary methods, or experimental choice tasks, to assess whether similar patterns emerge in actual media behavior. Future research should also examine whether these findings extend across national contexts, particularly where the distinction between progressive-conservative and left-right self-placement maps differently onto cultural, economic, and moral-political divisions.

Third, the observed associations were generally modest. Although this is typical of large-scale media-preference research, where media choices are influenced by numerous psychological, social, cultural, and contextual factors, it suggests that narrational complexity preferences should be understood as one contributor among many rather than a dominant determinant of media behavior. Future research could examine additional psychological, social, and environmental factors that jointly shape preferences for narrational complexity.

Conclusion

This study examined whether preferences for narrational complexity are associated with broader cognitive and political orientations. The findings show that preference for narrational complexity is meaningfully associated with cognitive styles linked to ambiguity tolerance and effortful thinking. Individuals who were more tolerant of ambiguity and higher in need for cognition reported stronger preferences for narrationally complex stories, and these same

cognitive styles were associated with less conservative ideological self-placement. Political orientation and voting intention were also associated with preference for narrational complexity, although these associations were modest and partly accounted for by cognitive styles.

More broadly, the findings suggest that politically relevant differences in entertainment preference concern not only narrative content, genre, or values, but also the way narrative information is organized and presented. Narrational complexity therefore provides a valuable lens for understanding how stable cognitive dispositions shape media preferences and, more broadly, how individuals engage with ambiguity, interpretive effort and uncertainty in cultural and daily life.

Author Contributions

Gaia Nuriya Yonah: Conceptualization; Methodology; Formal Analysis; Investigation; Writing – Original Draft; Writing – Review & Editing.

Cynthia Cabañas: Supervision; Writing - Review & Editing.

Mariken van der Velden: Conceptualization; Methodology; Data Curation; Supervision; Writing – Review & Editing.

Katalin Bálint: Conceptualization; Methodology; Supervision; Funding Acquisition; Writing – Review & Editing.

Elly Konijn: Supervision; Writing – Review & Editing.

All authors approved the final version of the manuscript and agree to be accountable for all aspects of the work.

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Disclosure of Interest

The authors report there are no competing interests to declare.

Declaration of Generative AI Use

Generative AI tools, including ChatGPT, Gemini 3.5, and DeepSeek, were used to support language refinement, code organization, and analytical workflow checking during preparation of this manuscript. ChatGPT was used through various available models between 2024 and 2026; version information for DeepSeek was not retained. No data were uploaded to or processed by these tools. AI-assisted suggestions related to code or analysis were independently reviewed by the authors, checked against the intended model specifications, compared across tools where relevant, and verified against the resulting statistical output. The authors confirm that all analytical decisions, interpretation of findings, and conclusions were made by the authors in consultation with the supervisory team. The authors have confirmed the originality and accuracy of the manuscript content, take full responsibility for the integrity of the work, including the accuracy of references, and have retained records of the AI-assisted workflow where applicable.

Data Availability Statement

The materials, raw data, analysis code, and additional analytical details supporting the findings of this study are available in the Online Compendium at

<https://github.com/MarikenvdVelden/politics-pnc/>.

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Table 1.

Descriptive statistics and Pearson correlations among study variables (lower triangle).

Measure	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	ω	correlations								
				1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. PNC	3.21	0.32	.89									
2. ToA	3.45	0.33	.70	.35***								
3. NfC	3.76	0.62	.81	.32***	0.53							
4. Progressive-conservative ideology	4.78	2.00	—	-.15***	.19***	-.15***						
5. Left-right ideology	5.23	2.39	—	-.15***	.12***	-.05*	.48***					
6. Voting intention	60.79%	—	—	-.17***	.10***	-.08***	.47***	.73***				
7. NCE	23.6	34.7	.94	.21***	.16***	.16***	-.07**	-.07**	-.11***			
8. Age	57.0	16.6	—	-.25***	.22***	-.25***	.07**	.08***	.13***	-.23***		
9. Gender	58.5%	—	—	-.03	.01	.05*	.16***	.23***	.20***	.03	.02	
10. Education	2.25	.74	—	.25***	.30***	.38***	-.14***	-.14***	.18***	.15***	-.25***	.06**

Note. PNC = preference for narrational complexity; ToA = tolerance for ambiguity; NfC = need for cognition; NCE = narrational complexity exposure. Reliability coefficients are reported as omega (ω) for multi-item scales. Correlations are Pearson's *r* and are shown in the lower triangle. For binary variables, descriptive

entries indicate the percentage in the category coded 1. Voting intention was coded 1 = conservative, and gender was coded 1 = male. Analytic sample for the primary SEM: $N=2,311$. $p < .05$, $p < .01$, $p < .001$

Table 2.
Model Fit Statistics and R^2 for Primary SEM

Fit Index	Primary SEM (Continuous)	Voting SEM (WLSMV)
χ^2 (df)	23.40 (6)	37.01 (6)
p-value	< .001	< .001
Robust CFI	.993	.994
Robust TLI	.964	.986
Robust RMSEA	.036	.037
90% CI for RMSEA	[.021, .052]	[.021, .054]
SRMR	.010	.018
Endogenous Variable	R^2	R^2
Latent cognitive styles factor (need for cognition & tolerance of ambiguity)	.263	.268
PNC (Complex Narrative Preference)	.223	.229
Prog.-Cons. Ideology	.076	.078
Left-Right Ideology	.067	.078
Voting Intention		.770
NCE (Narrational complexity Exposure)	.090	

Figure 1.

*Path diagram for the structural equation model. Standardized coefficients (β) are shown. Solid lines indicate statistically significant or marginally significant paths; dashed lines indicate non-significant paths. Significance markers refer to the statistical significance of each individual path coefficient based on the unrounded estimate and its standard error: † $p < .10$, * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$. Control variables (age, sex, education) and residual covariances are omitted for clarity.*

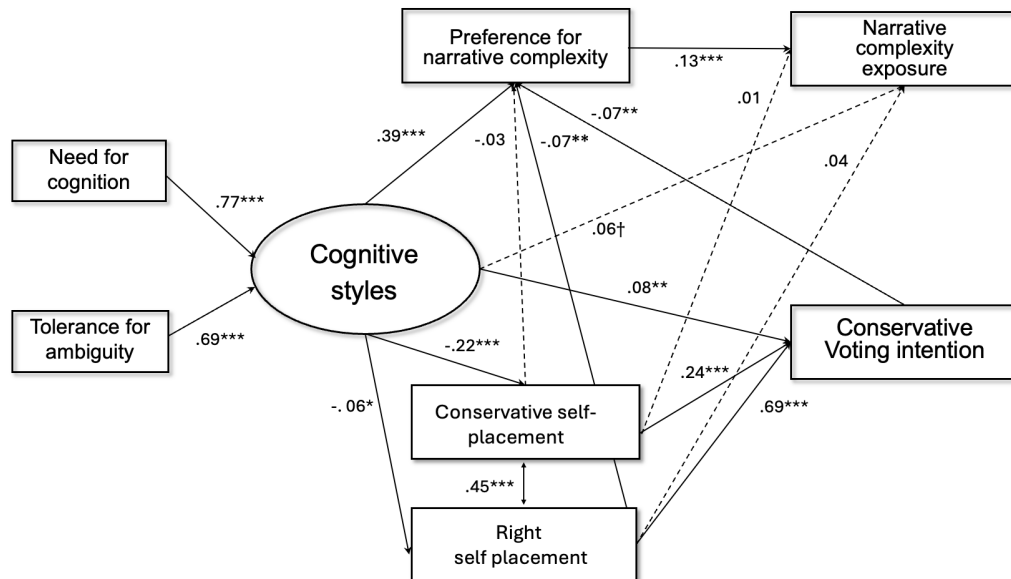


Table 3.

Parameter Estimates for Final Structural Equation Model

Path	Estimate	Std. Err	z-value	p-value	Std.all (β)
Measurement Model (Loadings)					
CogStyle → TOA	0.193	0.007	26.20	< .001	.690

CogStyle → NFC	0.406	0.014	28.96	< .001	.767
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Structural Regressions	Estimate	Std. Err	z-value	p-value	Std.all (β)
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(Hypotheses)

Outcome: Preference for

Narrative Complexity (PNC)

← Cognitive styles	0.08	0.006	12.43	< .001	0.39
← Conservative Self-placement	-0.003	0.003	-1.25	0.208	-0.03
← Right-wing Self-placement	-0.01	0.002	-3.17	0.002	-0.07

**Outcome: Conservative self
placement**

← Cognitive styles	-0.37	0.053	-6.98	< .001	-0.22
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**Outcome: Right-wing self-
placement**

← Cognitive styles	-0.12	0.062	-2	0.046	-0.06
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Outcome: Narrative Complexity

Exposure (NCE)

← PNC	0.55	0.101	5.4	< .001	0.13
← Cognitive styles	0.05	0.029	1.86	0.063	0.06
← Conservative Self-placement	0.01	0.012	0.48	0.635	0.01
← Right-wing Self-placement	-0.02	0.01	-1.65	0.099	-0.04

Outcome: Voting Intention**(Conservative)**

← PNC	-0.63	0.205	-3.07	0.002	-0.07
← Cognitive Styles	0.14	0.057	2.42	0.016	0.08
← Conservative Self-placement	0.25	0.019	13.23	< .001	0.24
← Right-wing Self-placement	0.59	0.024	24.68	< .001	0.69

Residual Covariance

Progressive-conservative

ideology ~ Left-right ideology	1.98	0.107	18.56	< .001	0.45
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